

What does EESL look for in channel partners? Who all is this programme open for?

Let me start by telling you about the UJALA programme that EESL has been conducting successfully in the country. We distributed LED bulbs under this from offices of discoms, post offices, and various other places. In the process we found that the real success was in bringing the local entrepreneurs to the table—local entrepreneurs who could run the sales for EESL. Now that was a programme which was more of a business to customer (B2C) thing.

This channel programme, however, is targeted more towards institutions and organisations. We have managed a good success rate in the programme where we were targeting to replace old bulbs with LEDs in Indian households. EESL is now targeting to bring entrepreneurs who can sell energy-saving solutions to corporates. We have tried to keep the thought process very simple. We have a clear plan for onboarding more and more eligible and qualified channel partners for better outreach.

My view is anybody who wants to be a part of the energy efficiency movement can be a part of this movement, and it is very easy to be a part of this movement. All we seek is a good credible standing, and the ability to be able to sell. We have opened this programme for individuals, for proprietorship firms, and for all other kinds of legal entities. All one needs to apply for this programme is a legal establishment. EESL seeks to register people that have a valid GST and PAN number.

We also seek an empanelment guarantee from the bank for one lakh (100,000) rupees. Our team is of the view that this amount can be earned by a channel partner within the first few months itself.

How is this programme different from the B2C ones EESL organised earlier?

This new programme does not allocate territories to any of the channel partners. We observed that assigning territories promotes kind of a rent seeking behaviour. We found that when we give territories, some work can be passed on to others by the channel partners in exchange of some rent. While planning this new programme we were sure about not wanting that kind of behaviour in this one.

The process in this new programme is innovative as we are giving leads to people who have the ability to go to a

corporate house and have a discussion around the energy saving solutions EESL offers, entice interest, and close the lead.

The team at EESL also trains channel partners about how to convert a lead into a sale, and how they can earn referrals from the same lead. The whole cycle, for the channel partner and EESL, begins with some basic qualification of the customer opportunity. This customer opportunity is the lead or the territory that is assigned to a channel partner. EESL partners with its channel partners in closing the sale. Any quotations, billing, or support that a channel partner needs, we will support the same as much as possible.

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And as we train our channel partners, we hope that they will become custodians of our customers, and make sure that their energy efficiency needs are met in time. It is a very simple programme where we have started with basic energy efficiency programmes like bulbs, tubelights, super-efficient, ACs, and motors. As we go forward and open inputs from our partners, we may open more programmes in future.

Where can one apply for the programme?

We run these programmes on a regular basis by opening the empanelments. At this moment of time, we have about 200 applicants. We are currently onboarding them and enrolling them in one batch. As the programme is outcome oriented, we have to handhold every batch to enable them to earn from the programme. There is enough in the programme for an individual or an institution to earn primary income. Earning 30 to 40 lakh (3 to 4 million) rupees is not difficult

for a partner who has access to 20 to 30 customers in a city.

We plan to keep opening this programme again and again, keep taking and training batches. EESL plans to open entries for new applicants every quarter. This is because we have to make efforts to make channel partners effective in terms of product knowledge and how to close a sale. EESL trains its channel partners on a lot of things including how to give energy efficient calculation reports for various products. It normally requires three months for a channel partner to go through all the training and become effective. We are looking to add 1,000 such channel partners this financial year.

What happens when someone becomes a partner of EESL? What's the overall process?

EESL starts by verifying the application. We also do a little reputation check of the applicants. This check includes any previous fraud or criminal activities verification. The next phase is signing of an empanelment agreement with EESL and submitting the empanelment bank guarantee (EBG). The idea is that a channel partner can start submitting leads as soon as they sign the agreement and deposit the EBG. There's a month's time given to submit EBG.

We usually start conducting the first session of training even before the EBGs are deposited. This training usually includes introduction to EESL, the programme, how the lead management works, and what are the different kinds of products they would be selling. After that it is a hand holding process where our team will get involved and help them in closing the sales. Once a sale is closed, the channel partner who closed the lead becomes entitled to the account. Then we expect that channel partner to submit and work on more leads from the same account for a year. However, we do not restrain others from submitting leads, and that's the innovation in this programme. If too many leads are coming from other channel partners, then it is a signal that this partner has lost touch with a particular account.

Is there a review of accounts as well?

Yes, there is a review of accounts and it normally happens once every year. During review we see how many leads came through an account. If a channel partner is losing touch with the account and a lot of leads from